



By **Pramath Raj Sinha**

INDIA AS A GLOBAL STUDY CENTRE

Outdated curricula, inadequate infrastructure and ill-trained faculty have been the bane of Indian higher education. A structural overhaul, strict oversight and emphasis on digital education will raise standards to global levels

Big is not always beautiful. With over 58,000 institutions and 43 million students, India's higher education system is one of the biggest in the world. But the overall perception of our colleges and universities is poor and, indeed, our institutions are plagued by issues of low quality. Addressing these deficiencies requires a three-pronged approach focused on systemic change. Without this, India cannot become a global hub for higher education; we need to become high-quality locally to be perceived as an attractive centre internationally.

Currently, there is a huge disparity in the quality of education. While prestigious public institutions like the IITs and IIMs and private ones such as Ashoka University and ISB take pains to maintain high standards, most colleges and universities struggle with outdated curricula, inadequate infrastructure and ill-trained faculty. This uneven playing field not only leaves thousands of students poorly-educated and ill-prepared for the real world, it also perpetuates inequality in life.

To address this, India needs to introduce a credible and reliable accreditation system that authentically evaluates higher education institutions. We need multiple independent organisations to strictly assess and benchmark the quality of our institutions. They should accurately measure and offer unbiased information about all aspects of the education being imparted at each institution. One, they should throw light on the quality of the faculty, the infrastructure and facilities, student outcomes as well as the overall campus experience. Two, they should highlight the differences between one institution and another. Most importantly, they should provide this information to students, parents and institutions in a transparent manner. Accreditation is a norm internationally and has led to the rise of first-class higher education systems in Europe, US and SE Asia. However, accreditation doesn't equal ranking.

A robust and trustworthy accreditation system helps students and parents to know exactly what to expect from which university, down to career prospects. Two, organisations striving to achieve or maintain accreditation status get motivated to adopt best practices, invest in their faculty and enhance

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